



THE FIFTH AGREEMENT

A Practical Guide to Self-Mastery

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The Big “So What” ???

This book taps into ancient Toltec wisdom to help you break free from limiting beliefs and social conditioning. It offers powerful insights to help you transform your reality, live authentically, and gain self mastery, thereby enjoy greater clarity, freedom, purpose, and inner peace.

Introduction



Toltec wisdom is a way of living that focuses on self-mastery, love, happiness, and understanding yourself and the world.

- It's not a religion but a guide to living with inner peace, drawing on universal truths found in many ancient spiritual teachings.
- Toltec wisdom respects all spiritual leaders but doesn't follow any specific belief system. Instead, it helps you connect with your true self, find joy, and live authentically.



Toltec wisdom was preserved by generations of “naguals” (masters). Don Miguel Ruiz is a nagual and spiritual teacher from the Toltec Eagle Knight lineage. In his previous book, *The Four Agreements*, he introduced 4 core principles to help individuals live with greater authenticity and freedom. In this book, he partners with his son Don Jose Ruiz to add a 5th principle along with deeper insights and practical guidance for self-transformation.

KEY QUOTES

“The result of practicing the fifth agreement is the complete acceptance of yourself just the way you are, and the complete acceptance of everybody else just the way they are. The reward is your eternal happiness.”

“When we master love, intent, or faith, we master the dream of our life, and when all three masteries are accomplished, we reclaim our divinity and become one with God. This is the goal of the Toltec.”



The Power of Symbols



Humans create symbols to help us make sense of the world and relate to each other. Symbols include language, social constructs, signs and concepts that we use to think, understand the world, and express ourselves.

- When we were first born, we perceived the world directly without judgment. We acted according to our DNA programming, or the biological blueprint that guides our innate responses and impulses.
- As we grew up, we became "domesticated" by society. We learned what's "good" or "bad", and what's "acceptable" or "unacceptable". These shape our beliefs and behaviors, leading us to act in line with social norms, often at the expense of our true selves. We even justify why we should curb our instincts to conform with the "correct" behaviors we've learned to accept.
- Once we master certain languages and symbols, we start to think and express ourselves through those symbols, allowing them to further shape our perception.



Symbols have no intrinsic truth; they only have meaning because we collectively agree on them. For instance, the words "table" or "tree" only mean something because of our shared understanding.

- Symbols cannot reflect the whole truth. For instance, hearing the word "bird" brings an image to your mind, but that image is influenced by what you've learned and experienced; it doesn't reflect the universal truth about birds.
- In fact, symbols can hold different meaning for different people, giving rise to misunderstandings. For example:
 - (i) In many Western cultures, the color white is associated with purity and weddings, but in some Eastern cultures like China and India, it's associated with death and funerals.
 - (ii) In English-speaking countries, "gift" refers to something given freely while in German it means "poison."

KEY QUOTES

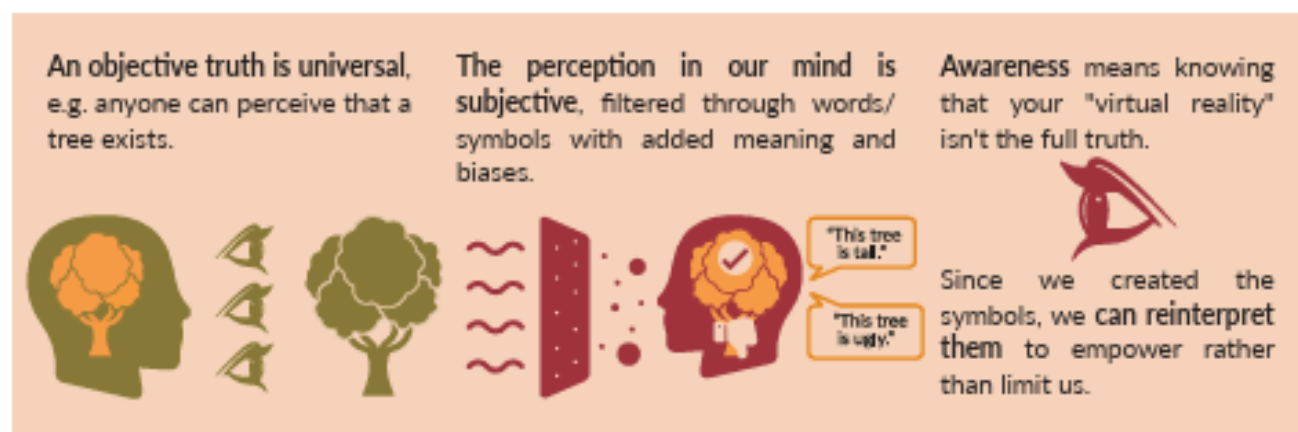
"All of our knowledge, 100 percent of it, is nothing more than symbolism or words that we invent for the need to understand and express what we perceive."

"Symbols only have value because we assign them a value and agree on their meaning. If we don't agree, the symbols are meaningless."

"Everything that exists is true: the earth is true, the stars are true, the entire universe has always been true. But the symbols that we use to construct what we know are only true because we say so."

"To be aware means to open our eyes to see the truth. When we see the truth, we see everything just as it is, not the way we believe it is, not the way we wish it to be."

- There's a real difference between objective truth and subjective interpretation. An objective truth is universally visible, like how everyone can perceive that a tree exists. But how we describe it—whether it's "tall" or "beautiful"—is subjective.
- Awareness means recognizing that what we perceive isn't the full truth. Once we're aware that symbols and beliefs can distort objective truth, we can consciously separate objective facts from subjective interpretations, allowing us to see life more clearly and to live authentically.



KEY QUOTES

"Humans are born with the power of creation, and we are constantly creating stories with the words that we learned."

"Awareness opens the door to millions of possibilities, and if we know that we are the artist of our own life, we can make a choice from all those possibilities."

"You were programmed to deliver a message, and the creation of that message is your greatest art. What is the message? Your life."

The Five Agreements



These 5 Agreements represent conscious choices or commitments to ourselves. They jointly help us to replace self-limiting patterns with empowering ones, leading to personal freedom, clarity, and mastery.



The First Agreement: Be Impeccable with Your Word



Words are powerful because they shape reality and wield the power to create or destroy.

- Words influence our attitudes, beliefs, emotions, and actions, impacting how we perceive ourselves and the world.
 - *Positive words* can uplift and heal us, e.g. if someone told you "You are capable" or "You can achieve anything if you set your mind to it."
 - *Negative words* can crush and destroy, e.g. if someone told you "You are a failure" or "You will never amount to anything."

"You're telling yourself a story, but is it the truth?"

"If you're asking yourself why you're so miserable at times, it's because you're telling yourself a story that isn't true, but you believe it."



We each create a story of ourselves in our minds—a narrative of who we *think* we are, constructed from beliefs, values, and judgments shaped by societal influence. We become deeply invested in this story and see it as our truth, when in reality it's just a reflection of others' opinions, labels, and expectations.



Over time, we absorb many ideas, values, and assumptions from our family, society, and culture. These form a belief system that shapes our “virtual self.” The Toltecs call this construct the “human form.”

- Our belief system acts like self-imposed laws, trapping our “real self” beneath layers of judgments, comparisons, and stories. It disconnects us from our true essence.
- Often, these ideas contradict each other, pulling us in opposite directions and diluting the power of our words and actions. When our intentions are free from conflicting beliefs and aligned in one direction, our words and actions become clear and powerful, enabling us to manifest our true desires.



When we invest our power in symbols, beliefs, and judgments, we allow them to control us. But since we're the ones who assigned meaning to these symbols, we can also reclaim our power and choose to use the symbols as neutral tools for communication.

- For instance, as children, many of us believed in Santa Claus and tried to behave to “earn” our rewards. Once we understand that Santa isn't real, it no longer influences our thoughts or actions.



In other words, there are 2 versions of you, and only one version is “real”.

- Your “virtual self” is a construct of the learned beliefs and knowledge from societal interactions and symbols—it includes all the judgments in your mind about whether you are good or bad, worthy or unworthy, beautiful or ugly. Ultimately, every judgment is just an opinion, and you are free to change that opinion.
- The “real self” is the authentic human being (you) that exists independent of both personal opinions and societal expectations.

KEY QUOTES

“The problem is not really knowledge; the problem is believing in a distortion of knowledge—and that is what we call a lie.”

“If we are the one who put the power of our faith in every symbol, then we are the only one who can take that power back.”

“If we could see our mind in action, we would see... that we are giving life to our creation by giving it the power of our faith, by giving it all of our attention.”

“Every judgment is just an opinion — it's just a point of view.”



Being impeccable with your words means only using words aligned with truth, and avoiding judgments, criticism, or negativity, whether directed at yourself or others.

- Speak with integrity: choose your words carefully, using only words that align with the truth and your real intention. Avoid subjective judgments that distort reality.
- Lean toward love and truth. Refrain from using words to judge, reject, criticize, gossip, or spread negativity about yourself or others.



The Second Agreement: Don't Take Anything Personally



Each person's mind is a unique world, constructed from their beliefs, memories, and interpretations.

- Imagine how an ant and a cat might perceive a mouse differently. Likewise, when 2 different people look at the same situation, they experience a different and unique version of reality.
- We assume that what we perceive is the truth, when in reality it is just a distorted version of the truth, filtered through the beliefs, assumptions, and biases of our own minds.
 - When you see a reflection in a mirror, it looks like the real thing even though it's just a reflection of light.
 - Our mind also reflects reality, but it distorts the image based on beliefs and biases, creating a "virtual reality" that may not align with the actual world.
- We also imagine and daydream frequently when we're awake, and dream when we're asleep. Such mental images continually shape and reshape our stories, altering our perception over time.
- In short, we each live in our own mental world, unaware that others' experiences and perceptions differ vastly from ours.



Other people's words and actions are less about you, and more a reflection of their own reality, beliefs, and emotional state. This leads to the second agreement: don't take anything personally.

KEY QUOTES

"Be impeccable with your word really means never use the power of the word against yourself. When you're impeccable with your word, you never betray yourself. You never use the word to gossip about yourself or to spread emotional poison by gossiping about other people."

"The world is populated by billions of dreamers who aren't aware that people are living in their own world, dreaming their own dream."

"The world we think we see outside of us is actually inside of us. It's just images in our imagination. It's a dream."

"Even if you try to tell the same story, your story is always changing. At a certain point, you find out that it's nothing but a story. It isn't reality; it's a virtual reality. It's nothing but a dream."

- You're not responsible for others' actions and opinions, nor can you control them.
 - We assume we know others well, when in reality we know very little about their inner/virtual world.
 - In fact, we don't even truly know ourselves, since our self image is distorted by our roles, beliefs, and assumptions.
- Instead of wasting mental energy on assumptions, use it to focus on understanding the truth instead.
- When we stop taking things personally and let go of others' judgments, we free ourselves from unnecessary emotional pain, misunderstandings, and conflict. We stop feeling pressured to defend ourselves, and enjoy greater peace and personal freedom.



The Third Agreement: Don't Make Assumptions



Assumptions are the stories we tell ourselves without knowing the full truth. They distort the truth and are often outright lies.

- These lies are often rooted in beliefs that don't align with reality. Imagine a vacant house that looks old and weathered. Someone decides, "This house gives me a strange feeling." Another person agrees, "Yes, I think it's creepy." The superstition grows until everyone agrees the house is cursed.
- Often, 1 lie leads to another, until we spin a web of lies that make it hard to see the truth. When each person spins their own story, it clouds reality, leading us away from universal truth.
- What we assume to be "true" often isn't so. At one point, people believed the world was flat, but this is now proven to be wrong. Likewise, much of what we "know" now are also wrong or false.



Lies and assumptions lead to both inner and outer conflicts, which cause pain and unhappiness.

- False assumptions can become personal or amplified, escalating pain and conflict. For example:

KEY QUOTES

"The only person who needs to be concerned about the story of you is you. This awareness changes everything."

"To realize that our mind is always dreaming gives us the key to changing our dream if we're not enjoying it."

"All conflict is the result of lies, because the truth has no conflict at all. The truth doesn't need to prove itself; it exists whether we believe in it or not."

"Lies are nothing but superstitions, and I can assure you that we live in a world of superstition. But again, are we aware of it?"

"Making assumptions and then taking them personally is the beginning of hell in this world. Almost all of our conflicts are based on this."

"We only see what we want to see; we only hear what we want to hear. Our belief system is just like a mirror that only shows us what we believe."

KEY QUOTES

"Assumptions are nothing more than lies that we are telling ourselves. This creates a big drama for nothing, because we don't really know if something is true or not."

"If we don't make assumptions, we can focus our attention on the truth, not on what we think is the truth. Then we see life the way it is, not the way we want to see it."

"When we recover all the energy that we invested in making assumptions, we can use that energy to create a new dream: our personal heaven."

"Always do your best is the agreement that everybody can do. Your best is, in fact, the only thing you can do."

- (i) We might feel hurt or resentful because we assume someone's delayed response means rejection, when in reality they haven't even seen our message.
 - (ii) When we overthink or dwell on fears and insecurities, we escalate our mental drama and emotional turmoil.
 - (iii) When we gossip, we spread distorted versions of events and amplify misunderstandings.
- When we're trapped in lies, we live in a state of inner "hell". When we free ourselves from lies and assumptions, we find peace or a personal "heaven".
 - One of the biggest lies today is that "nobody's perfect". Everything in nature—including each human being—is inherently perfect once you stop measuring them against arbitrary standards.
 - Consider a flower in a garden. Some might see it as "too short" or "too wild." But who's to say what a "perfect" flower should be like? Likewise, every person is perfect in their own way, even if they have certain disabilities or diseases.



To stop making assumptions, we must cultivate awareness—to actively question our own beliefs and be open to other perspectives.

- See your assumptions as subjective interpretations, not objective truths. Challenge assumptions to interrupt automatic judgments, stay open-minded, and reduce unnecessary drama and conflict.
- Stop overthinking and trying to explain or justify everything. Instead, accept that you don't know everything, and ask good questions to gain clarity.



The Fourth Agreement: Always Do Your Best



Doing your best means applying the 3 agreements earlier to the best of your ability, based on your current capacity and situation.

- Don't strive for perfection or dwell on past failures and future worries.
 - (i) Accept that your *"best"* will vary with your energy, mood, and circumstances.
 - (ii) Just focus on what you can do in the moment, giving it your full effort.
- When you practice the four agreements daily, even if imperfectly, you will progressively internalize them until they become habitual.
 - (i) You will gradually weaken habits like speaking carelessly, taking things personally, or making assumptions. You will also improve your baseline *"best level."*
 - (ii) Each time you dismantle a limiting belief, you reclaim the personal power you had invested in it, and strengthen the alignment with your true self.



The key is to keep doing your best without self-judgment. In so doing, you commit to the path of self-transformation.

- If you falter on any agreement, just renew your commitment without self-reproach.
- The ultimate goal is to replace limiting beliefs with the four agreements, aligning yourself with truth and freedom. Transformation occurs when you unlearn old beliefs and conditioned ideas that no longer serve you, and embrace new truths and self-love instead.



The Fifth Agreement: Be Skeptical, but Learn to Listen



The first 3 Agreements guide us toward the truth, the Fourth Agreement helps us to internalize them, while the Fifth Agreement gives us a way to consciously deepen the practice of the original four agreements in real life.

- It uses doubt as a tool to question beliefs, separate truth from falsehood, and release agreements that no longer serve us. By challenging ingrained beliefs and internal/external messages, we free ourselves from limiting beliefs that constrain us.

KEY QUOTES

"Eventually the moment will come when all four agreements become a habit. You don't even try. It's automatic. It's effortless. One day you discover that you are ruling your life with the Four Agreements."

"By doing your best, over and over, eventually you are going to master the art of transformation."

"You can relearn how to love yourself by accepting yourself, unconditionally. And you can start by projecting unconditional love to the authentic you."

"If faith is believing without a doubt, and doubt is not believing, be skeptical. Don't believe."

"Instead of doubting yourself, have faith in yourself. Instead of doubting the truth, doubt the lies."



The Fifth Agreement is about balancing skepticism with listening.

- Be skeptical: Don't believe anything at face value, since everyone's "truth" is filtered through subjective perceptions, and no single story or symbol reflects the whole truth. However, don't feign skepticism just to appear smart or superior.
- Instead, listen with openness. Recognize that people naturally communicate through stories, not out of an intention to deceive.
 - (i) Listen respectfully, giving others the space to express their perceived truths without judging, agreeing, or disagreeing.
 - (ii) Seek to understand their worldview or perspective without taking their words personally or being affected by them.
 - (iii) Once you grasp what they want, it's up to you to choose your response—to agree, disagree, share your views, or ignore the message altogether.
- In the same token, the authors' words in this book are merely a reflection of their own perspectives. Listen to understand, then choose if and how to integrate these insights into your own beliefs. With awareness, you always have a choice.



Once we stop trying to label, judge, or explain everything, we uncover a world where things are inherently perfect just as they are, without the need for validation.

- You can embrace sensory experiences (like the feel of a sofa or your body's sensations) without labeling them as "good" or "bad." Even emotions or mistakes are neither positive nor negative—they simply exist.
- Although you still think and communicate using symbols, you can choose your words and interpretations to create a story that brings you peace and joy, without getting attached to it.

KEY QUOTES

"To be skeptical is not to believe everything you hear."

"The truth doesn't come with words. The truth is silent. It's something that you just know; it's something that you can feel without words, and it's called silent knowledge."

"Once you recover awareness, you become completely responsible for your own evolution—for every choice you make in life."

"Even though you know your story isn't true, you can create the most beautiful story, and you can guide your life through that story. You can create your personal heaven and live in that heaven. And if you can understand other people's stories, and they can understand yours, then together you can create the most beautiful dream."



The Journey to Freedom

»» According to Toltec wisdom, we progress through 3 stages or "dreams" of attention, each representing a deeper level of awareness and understanding of reality.

🚫 In the first stage (the "Dream of the First Attention"), we accept societal "truths" without question, forming our worldview based on the symbols and stories we're taught.

- The authors use the biblical story of Adam and Eve to symbolize how we got disconnected from our true essence. When we ate from the Tree of Knowledge (also known as the Tree of Death), we gained "knowledge" of what was right or wrong. In doing so:
 - We "died" spiritually because we stopped seeing ourselves as whole and perfect. We started to experience judgment, guilt, fear and doubt, and our "virtual self" took charge instead of our real, authentic self.
- Awakening from this dream is like a resurrection of our true self. It reconnects us to the unity, love, and truth symbolized by the Tree of Life. We return to the state of innocence, inner freedom, and paradise that it represents. It's like a spiritual rebirth that revives our inner essence, so we start to live with authentic awareness and see life without the cloud of judgment and fear.

👊 Once we're aware that our perceptions aren't the full truth, we begin the next phase—the "Dream of the Second Attention". We start to question and dismantle limiting beliefs/agreements to reclaim our personal freedom gradually.

- This stage becomes a mental battleground where we work to free our authentic self from layers of false agreements and beliefs.
- In ancient times, people offered sacrifices to gods like Apollo or Zeus. Today, we are still making sacrifices.
 - We give up our peace, authenticity, or relationships for modern "gods"—ideals like democracy, justice, or even personal pride.

KEY QUOTES

*"You are truth; you are life;
you are love."*

*"The first lie that we believe
is 'I am not God.' We see the
beauty and perfection of
God, and we want to be like
God— we want to be that
"image of perfection"—and
we search and search for
perfection."*

*"You are not who you really
are, because you have been
possessed by that distorted
image of you...And that
distorted image of yourself is
really your grave, because the
real you is not the one who is
living your life."*

*"You have a choice. You can
create heaven, or you can
create hell. Remember, both
are states of mind that exist
within you."*

*"Humans are the only
animals on earth who punish
themselves a thousand times
or more for the same mistake,
and who punish everybody
else a thousand times or
more for the same mistake."*

- We also carry baggage from the past, often punishing ourselves and others repeatedly for past mistakes. These open up old wounds, trapping us in emotional turmoil and limiting our ability to live freely in the present.
- Religious teachers like Jesus, Buddha, or Muhammad can provide guidance, but they cannot live our lives for us. Only you have the power to change your perception, and by extension, your reality.
- Life operates on action-reaction, e.g. self-judgment (action) leads to guilt and shame (reaction). The only way to change the outcome is to change our initial action.
- The Five Agreements serve as tools to help us dismantle ingrained, fear-based beliefs, gradually freeing us from the illusions of the “virtual self” so we can live authentically and pursue our true desires. The lies still exist all around us; we simply choose not to invest in them.



The Dream of the Third Attention is the ultimate state of freedom and mastery, where we see life as it truly is, free from personal stories, boundaries, or filters. This stage embodies pure awareness and unity with all of existence.

- The “Last Judgment” is commonly interpreted in several religions—like Christianity or Islam—as a final reckoning by God. However, the authors describe it not as an external event, but an internal process where we let go of all judgments about ourselves and others, to find inner peace here and now.
- When we remove all symbols and labels, we come to see that everything—ourselves included—is part of one unified force. Just as every drop is part of the ocean, each of us is a unique expression the same universal life force.
- With this realization, we experience *oneness* with all of creation, including the divine. We realize we're not merely humans experiencing life, but life itself.

KEY QUOTES

“It’s not up to God or Jesus or Buddha or Moses or Muhammed or any master, shaman, or guru to save us... No one else can change our world, because that world only lives in our head.”

“The Four Agreements are the tools for using your attention a second time to create your personal heaven, and the fifth agreement is the tool to win the war against the tyranny of the symbols.”

“Once you have the awareness that almost everything you learned through symbols is not the truth, the only thing left is just to enjoy life, and that’s the resurrection.”

“Everything in existence is part of the only living being in existence...and you are that being. You are that force that manifests itself in infinite ways throughout all the universes.”

“That is what everything is, in billions and billions of different frequencies or manifestations of light. And together, all the different frequencies create only one light.”

- All life forms are *unique yet interconnected parts* of one vast, living universe. Every being—be it human, the Earth, or a galaxy—is complete in itself, yet part of a greater whole. Even an atom is like a miniature solar system, with electrons orbiting a nucleus.
- In this state of awareness and communion, love flows naturally and unconditionally from you, like sunlight shining on everything. This love isn't based on reasons or stories—it is a part of your being, because you're in harmony with the frequency of love. You can simply exist and enjoy that existence, without the need for judgments, words, or explanations.



The Truth will Set You Free



To see the truth, we must first unlearn what we think we know, letting go of illusions to connect with our genuine nature. The 3 Dreams mirror the 3 worlds found in many spiritual traditions:

- In Greek and Egyptian beliefs, they represent the Underworld (unconscious fears and conditioning), the World (our lived experiences), and the Upper World (divine awareness).
- In Christianity, these are symbolized as Hell (fear and illusion), Purgatory (the process of inner purification), and Paradise (complete unity with God).
- Toltec wisdom presents them as stages of attention, moving from the illusions of the first attention to ultimate clarity in the third.



All 3 worlds coexist within us, and we choose which one we engage with. To master the 3 Dreams, we must exercise deliberate control over our perceptions, and direct our life purposefully, free from external influences.

Other Details in the Book to Look out For



The Five Agreements are practical tools to help you dissolve false beliefs, connect deeply with your authentic self, and master your life.

KEY QUOTES

"It doesn't matter if we are a Christian, a Buddhist, a Muslim, a Hindu. We come from the same place, and we're going back to the same place. The infinite creates everything in existence, and when the cycle is over, everything returns to the infinite."

"The truth will set you free, but first you need to see the truth."

"Once you accept yourself just the way you are, you no longer have any judgments about yourself. Once you accept everybody else just the way they are, you no longer have any judgments about them. Then something incredible happens in your world: You find peace. You are not in conflict with yourself, and you are not in conflict with anyone else."

"You are here to enjoy life. You are not here to suffer over your drama or your personal importance."